THRONE OF ASHES

Volume 1: The Cursed Playmate

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Throne of Ashes · Volume 1: The Cursed Playmate

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CHAPTER 1

The Wish Beneath the Cherry Blossoms

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The Nile smells of fish, myrrh and rot, and in the market of Thebes I am ten years old again, with eighteen years of guilt behind my eyes.

But that comes later.

First, I have to die.

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JAPAN. SPRING. 7:42 A.M.

My parents were obsessed with history.

Other children got picture books about trains. I got a laminated chart of the Eighteenth Dynasty, taped to the wall above my bed, with the pharaohs' names in my mother's neat handwriting. Other families went to the beach on holidays. We went to museums, and my father stood in front of glass cases for so long that the guards started to watch him.

He would point at a cracked jar, or a broken statue with no nose, and say, "Kael. Somebody made this. Somebody's hands touched this, three thousand years ago. Think about that."

I thought about it.

I thought about it so much that I can still recite the kings of Egypt faster than I can recite my own phone number.

Three years ago, someone set fire to our house. My parents were inside. The police said arson, and then they said the case was open, and then they stopped saying anything at all.

The books survived. Most of them. They live in boxes in my rented room now, and they still smell of smoke.

So do I, some mornings.

◆

The cherry road is the long way to school.

Nobody takes it. It adds nine minutes. I know because I counted, the first week after the fire, when I needed something to count.

I take it every day.

The old trees lean over the lane from both sides, so the road becomes a tunnel of pink. Last night's rain still shines on the pavement. Petals stick to it like wet paper. At the bottom of the slope, the grey concrete of the school gate waits in cold shadow, the way it always does.

A vending machine hums beside the bus shelter.

My phone buzzes in my blazer pocket.

I don't take it out.

I already know what's on it. The homeroom group chat counting down the days to the entrance exams. A reminder from the university my parents taught at, cheerfully confirming my application to the history department. Two messages from the fencing club captain asking whether I'm *really* quitting.

And one from Soren.

My twin brother lives with our uncle in Osaka now. He writes to me every month, and every month I read the first line in the preview

and leave it there.

This month's first line says: *It's been three years. Are you coming on Sunday or not?*

Not.

I walk.

Thirty-one steps to the first lamppost. Twenty-eight to the second. I keep my eyes on the pavement and my breathing slow.

My reflection slides past in a puddle. Black hair that needs cutting. Black school uniform. A pale face that people say looks tired, and a thin white scar through my left eyebrow, where a training foil snapped at a tournament when I was twelve. It missed my eye by the width of a coin.

I looked at that scar in the mirror every day for a month afterward, feeling lucky.

I don't remember the last time I felt lucky.

◆

"Kael. Good morning."

Mrs. Hayashi is sweeping in front of her tea shop, the way she does every dawn. She is very old and very small, and she sweeps petals with the seriousness of a priest.

"Good morning, Mrs. Hayashi."

"You look terrible."

"Thank you. I studied late."

She makes a noise that tells me exactly what she thinks of studying late. Then she leans on her broom and studies me instead.

Mrs. Hayashi read old texts with my parents, back when I was too young to care what the texts said. She is the only adult in this town who still talks to me as if I'm a person and not a tragedy.

"Your mother's order came," she says.

I stop.

"Her order."

"Six books. From a dealer in Kyoto. She ordered them before…" Mrs. Hayashi's mouth tightens. "Before. They only found them this winter. I've been keeping them for you."

Six books my mother wanted. Six books she never got to open.

My hand moves on its own. I take out my wallet and pull out the only bill inside, a ten-thousand-yen note I'd been saving for something I can't remember now.

"How much do I owe you?"

She looks at the bill. She looks at me.

"Put that away. After school. I'll wrap them properly."

"I can pay now."

"After school," she says again, in a voice that ends the conversation. "Go. You'll be late."

I fold the bill twice and slide it into the breast pocket of my blazer, over my heart, where I won't forget it.

Then I bow, and keep walking.

Behind me, the broom starts again. *Scritch. Scritch.*

◆

Halfway down the slope stands the oldest tree.

It's twice as thick as the others, and so crooked it looks like it's bowing. Its roots have split around something at its base: a small stone shrine, no taller than my knee, its little door sealed with old grey mortar.

There's a mark carved over the door. A circle with a single line through it, like the face of a sundial with only its shadow left. The stone is worn so smooth that the mark is almost gone.

I've walked past it every day for three years. I don't know which god it belongs to. I've never asked.

Every morning, Mrs. Hayashi sweeps the shrine clean. Every morning, the old tree drops the same low branch across the pavement, as if it's doing it on purpose.

It's there now. I step over it.

On the other side of the lane, a group of elementary school kids are racing to the corner. Their yellow caps bob through the petals. One of them, a boy of nine or ten, is trying to catch the falling blossoms in his mouth.

He's wearing a blue shirt with red sleeves.

I had a shirt exactly like that. My mother bought it for a museum trip, the summer I turned ten. I wore it until the sleeves stopped at my elbows.

The boy misses a petal, trips, and lands on his backside on the wet pavement. His friends howl with laughter. He laughs too, louder than any of them, with his whole body.

I can't remember the last time I laughed like that.

That summer, I think. The museum. My father's hand on my shoulder in front of a gold mask, telling me the boy who wore it had been king at nine years old.

Think about that, Kael.

The kids run around the corner. Their voices fade.

The road is quiet.

My phone buzzes again. The pressure behind my eyes builds, the way it does every morning now, a weight that never quite lifts. Exams. Applications. A future my parents would have been proud of, picked out for me by everyone except me.

A brother I don't answer.

An empty room full of burned books.

My mother's voice, in the smoke.

I don't usually let myself remember that part. The fire, the heat, my father's shape in the doorway and then not. My mother on the grass outside, her hand gripping my sleeve, her eyes wide and clear. Her last words weren't "I love you." They weren't my name.

They were: *Don't let them forget his name.*

I still don't know whose name she meant.

I stand under the oldest tree and breathe, and a petal lands on my sleeve, and something in my chest that has been holding very still for three years finally gives way.

"I wish I was ten again," I say to no one. "Life was so much simpler."

The words hang in the cold air.

The branches over my head stop moving.

Every one of them, all at once, as if the whole tree is holding its breath. The petals in the air stop falling. They hang there, perfectly still, a pink snowfall frozen in place.

That's not—

CRACK.

It's as loud as a gunshot. Louder. It comes from under my feet.

The shrine's grey mortar splits down the middle. The roots heave. The pavement buckles, and the oldest tree on the cherry road tears itself open from the ground up, and leans, and keeps leaning.

Toward me.

Petals explode into the air in a storm of pink.

I see it coming. I have time to see it coming. Every fencing coach I ever had said I was fast, that I read an attack before it started.

My body doesn't move.

Of course, I think. *Just another variable I didn't account—*

The trunk comes down.

There's no pain. Just weight, enormous and final, and the smell of wet bark and spring rain, and somewhere very far away, the sound of a broom stopping.

My phone is still buzzing in my pocket.

Then it isn't.

Then nothing is.

NOWHERE. NO TIME.

I wake up because something is counting.

Tick.

Not a clock. Softer. Like a single grain of sand landing on glass.

Tick.

I open my eyes.

The sky above me is black. Not night-black. There are no stars, no moon, no clouds. It's the black of a closed eye.

And yet I can see.

I'm lying on my back in sand. Grey sand, fine as ash, cold under my palms. I sit up slowly, waiting for the pain of a crushed spine, broken ribs, anything.

Nothing hurts.

That frightens me more than pain would.

Tick.

I get to my feet.

The desert runs away in every direction, flat and grey and endless. And standing in it, in rows that stretch to the horizon, are sundials.

Thousands of them. Tens of thousands. Stone pillars as tall as my waist, each one topped with a round dial and a slanted blade of bronze. Some are carved with numbers I know. Some with symbols I half know: Roman numerals, Chinese characters, Egyptian glyphs, marks that might be older than writing.

There's no sun.

Every dial casts a shadow anyway.

And every shadow points at me.

"……"

I turn around. They turn too. Ten thousand thin black lines across the grey sand, all bending to follow me, like the needles of compasses that have found north.

Breathe, I tell myself. *Breathe. Think.*

The tree fell. I remember the weight. I remember the sound of the broom stopping.

So either this is a dream, or I'm in a hospital on very good drugs, or—

"You are dead, Kael."

The voice comes from behind me.

It isn't loud. It's dry and quiet, like pages turning in an empty library. But it lands in my bones, and every grain of sand in the desert trembles with it.

I turn around.

◆

There's someone sitting on the nearest sundial.

At least, I think it's someone. When I look straight at it, it's a man, tall and thin, wrapped in something pale. When I look at its face, the face isn't there. It's made of dust, the gold kind you see floating in a sunbeam through a dusty window, and the dust never settles long enough to become eyes or a mouth.

It's old. I don't know how I know. The way you know a mountain is old.

"You are dead," it says again, patiently, as if I'm a slow student. "The tree was older than you. It fell. That is all."

My mouth is dry. "Who are you?"

The dust shifts. It might be a smile.

"Your people have had many names for me. Most of them have forgotten all of them. I am the one who keeps what is gone." A hand made of drifting gold gestures at the sundials. "The past. I keep the past."

"The God of the Past," I say, and my own voice sounds thin and stupid in all that silence.

"If you like."

I should be screaming. I know that. Some part of me is screaming, a long way down, in the dark. But the part of me on top is the part that sat through three years of police interviews and funeral arrangements and paperwork with my parents' names on it, and that part has learned to go cold when things get bad.

So I go cold.

"If I'm dead," I say, "why am I talking to you?"

"Because you asked me for something."

"I didn't ask you for anything."

"You stood on my door and made a wish."

The shrine. The sealed stone shrine under the oldest tree, with the worn mark of a circle and a single line. Like a sundial with only its shadow left.

Oh.

"I wasn't talking to you," I say. "I wasn't talking to anyone."

"Everyone who speaks to the past is speaking to me." The dust leans forward. "*I wish I was ten again. Life was so much simpler.* Those were your words. I heard them. I have decided to grant them."

"No." It comes out too fast. "No. That's not what I meant. That's just something people *say*—"

"Is it?"

The god holds up one hand. In it, there's an hourglass.

It's small. Old glass, clouded and scratched, held in a frame of dark wood. The sand inside is the same dusty gold as the god's face.

"You will be a child again," it says. "In a time long past. Not your past. An older one."

It turns the hourglass over.

The sand begins to fall.

Tick.

So that was the sound.

"You have two years," the god says. "Two floods of the great river. When the second flood goes down, the past lets go of you, and you return to where you left."

"Where I left," I repeat.

Under the tree. Under the weight. On the wet pavement, with my phone buzzing in my pocket and Mrs. Hayashi's broom standing still.

"You're sending me back to die."

"You are already dead," the god says, gently. "I am lending you two years. What you do with them is yours."

"And if I don't want them?"

The god doesn't answer that.

The sand keeps falling.

◆

"Rules," I say. My hands are shaking. I fold them under my arms so it can't see. "If you're doing this, there have to be rules. Where am I going? How do I survive there? How do I get back? Can I get back?"

"You ask many questions."

"My parents were historians. Questions are all I have."

For the first time, the dust goes still.

"Yes," the god says softly. "I know who your parents were."

The cold in my chest turns to something sharper.

"What does that mean?"

"You will understand their tongue," the god says, as if I hadn't spoken, "and they will understand yours. The words will sit in your mouth like a borrowed tooth. They will hear that you are not one of them."

"What does that *mean*? What do you know about my parents?"

"You will keep what you carried closest to your heart. Nothing more."

"Answer me!"

The sundials flinch. Ten thousand shadows flicker. I have never shouted at anything in my life, and I've just shouted at a god.

The god looks at me with its face of falling dust for a long, long moment.

Then it says, in my mother's voice:

"Don't let them forget his name."

Every hair on my body stands up.

"Stop it."

"She understood," the god says, in its own voice again. "Not all of it. Enough."

"Understood *what*? Whose name? Why me? Why would you—"

The desert begins to blow away.

It starts at the horizon. The farthest sundials crumble into grains and lift into the black sky like smoke, and the wind carries them toward me, and there are pictures in the sand.

A river, brown and enormous, wider than any river should be.

A boy in a gold collar, sitting on a throne much too big for him.

Lamplight running along the edge of a blade.

A stone wall carved with a name inside an oval ring, and a chisel striking it, and striking it, and striking it, until the name is gone.

"Where are you sending me?" I shout over the wind. "*Why?*"

The god only smiles. I can't see its mouth, but I know it's smiling.

"Simple?" it says. "We shall see."

The sand hits me like a wave.

It fills my eyes, my mouth, my lungs. I'm falling. I'm shrinking. My bones fold in on themselves like a telescope closing, and my blazer turns heavy and huge around me and then isn't there at all, and the last thing I hear is that sound, that small, patient sound of time running out—

Tick.

—and then sunlight.

White, blinding, furious sunlight.

And the smell of fish.

THEBES. NOON.

The heat is the first thing.

Not warmth. *Heat.* It presses down on the back of my neck like a hand. It comes up off the ground through the soles of my bare feet. The air is so hot and dry that the first breath I take hurts all the way down.

The second thing is the noise.

Shouting. Hundreds of voices, all at once, somewhere close. A donkey braying like a broken hinge. The slap of water against wood. Someone laughing, someone arguing, someone singing three words over and over in a cracked, tuneless voice.

I'm lying in a narrow lane between two walls of mud brick. The walls are the colour of dry bread. A strip of sky above them burns so blue it looks painted.

I sit up.

I'm wearing a blue shirt with red sleeves.

I stare down at it for a long time.

It's the shirt. Not one like it. *The* shirt, from the museum summer, with the small ink stain on the hem where I tested my father's fountain pen and got scolded for it. Below it, a pair of faded shorts. No shoes. No blazer. No phone. No wallet.

My hands are in my lap.

They're small.

I hold them up. Thin wrists. Short, blunt fingers. The calluses from eight years of fencing grips are gone. On my left wrist, a frayed linen cord, the bracelet my mother wove for me, faded from red to the colour of old rust. It used to sit tight on my wrist. Now it hangs loose.

You will keep what you carried closest to your heart.

I touch the breast pocket of the shirt. Paper crackles inside. I pull it out.

A ten-thousand-yen note, folded twice.

"……"

I laugh. I don't mean to. It's a short, ugly sound, and it comes out high.

High and bright, like a child's.

I clap my hand over my mouth.

Breathe. Breathe. Think.

I stand up. The ground is much closer than it should be. The walls of the lane are much taller. I take a step and my balance is wrong, my centre of gravity too low, my legs too short, as if someone has rebuilt me out of smaller parts and forgotten to tell me.

I put one hand on the wall to steady myself.

Then I walk toward the noise.

◆

The lane opens, and the world falls on me.

A market. A huge one. A sea of linen awnings stretched on poles, sagging in the heat, row after row after row of them sloping down a dusty square toward a river.

And the river.

It's brown and enormous and slow, wider than any river I've ever seen. Wooden barges heavy with sacks of grain bump against a stone wharf, and half-naked men carry the sacks up the steps on their shoulders, singing. Beyond the river, a strip of green fields, so bright it hurts. And beyond that, desert. White, glowing, endless desert, and a line of pale cliffs on the horizon.

I turn my head.

Upriver, above the roofs, there's a wall of stone so high and long it looks like a cliff someone built on purpose. Behind it, a needle of stone stabs at the sky, its tip sheathed in something that throws the sun back like a mirror.

I know that needle.

I've seen it in photographs, grey and weathered, in the textbooks on my bedroom floor. I've never seen it with its tip still covered in gold.

An obelisk.

The great temple of Amun. Karnak.

Which means this river is the Nile. And this city is Thebes. *Waset,* my mother corrects, in my head, because she always insisted on the old names. *The city of Amun.*

In a time long past. Not your past. An older one.

I stand at the edge of the market of Thebes, three and a half thousand years before I was born, and I count.

Calm. Count. Find the exits.

Four streets lead out of the square. The wharf below. Mud-brick buildings on three sides, two storeys at most. A larger building with a

guarded gate, stacked with clay-sealed jars: a granary. The seals on the jars are stamped with a ram's head.

Amun's ram. Temple grain.

My father's voice, very dry: *Whoever owns the grain owns Egypt.*

The heat is making me dizzy. My stomach makes a noise. A long, painful, hollow noise.

When did I last eat?

Yesterday's dinner, eighteen years old, in my rented room, cold convenience-store rice. But this body didn't eat that. This body hasn't eaten anything, ever, as far as it knows. And it is starving.

◆

I let the crowd carry me in.

Everyone is taller than me. That's the first thing I learn about being ten again: the world is made of hips and elbows. I push between sweating bodies in white linen kilts, women in straight sheath dresses with braided black hair, a man with a shaved head carrying two geese by their necks. A boy my size runs past with a basket of onions and doesn't look at me twice.

Nobody looks at me twice.

Not yet.

The shouting is words now. I didn't notice when it changed. One moment it was noise, and the next it's a fishmonger yelling that his perch were swimming this morning, and a woman arguing about the weight of a copper ring, and a beer seller swearing by Hathor that his jars aren't watered.

I understand every word.

Each one arrives a half second late, like a film with the subtitles out of sync. And each one feels wrong in my head, heavy and strange.

The words will sit in your mouth like a borrowed tooth.

The smell of bread finds me before I see it.

It comes from a stall under a stained linen awning, where a big woman with flour on her forearms is pulling flat loaves out of a clay oven. Emmer bread, coarse and brown, with ash on the bottom. Beside her, on the counter, sits a wide jar of glazed blue clay, cracked down one side and full to the brim with water.

I stop in front of the counter. It comes up to my chest.

I look down into the jar.

A face looks back at me.

A child's face. Round-cheeked. Small chin. A pale, soft, foreign face that has never seen this much sun.

The hair is blond.

Not light brown. Not dyed. Gold-blond, the colour of the wheat stalks in a museum painting, falling in sharp, untidy layers across the forehead.

The eyes are blue.

My eyes were brown. My whole life, my eyes were brown.

There's only one thing in that face I recognise. A thin white scar, cutting down through the left eyebrow.

My scar. On a stranger.

I jerk back from the jar so fast I nearly fall. My heart is going like a fist on a door.

They gave me a different face.

No. They gave me a different everything, and left me the scar so I'd know it was still me.

"You going to buy something, or just stare at my water?"

The bread woman is looking down at me with her floury arms folded.

I open my mouth. What comes out is a child's voice, high and clear, speaking her language with an accent I can hear even through

my own ears.

"One loaf, please."

She looks at me differently. The way you look at a dog that just said a word.

"One loaf," she repeats. "With what?"

Barter, I think. *No coins yet. Grain, linen, copper by weight. Deben.*

I don't have grain, or linen, or copper.

I have a ten-thousand-yen note.

It's stupid. I know it's stupid even as I do it. But I'm so hungry that my hands are shaking, and some animal part of me that is very, very ten years old thinks: *money is money.*

I unfold the bill and hold it up.

◆

The woman takes it between two fingers.

She frowns. She turns it over. She holds it up to the light, and the watermark shows through, a ghostly face floating in the paper.

She drops it on the counter like it bit her.

"What is this?"

"It's money. Where I come from."

"Where is that?"

I don't answer.

She picks it up again, more carefully. "Who's this?" She taps the printed face of a stern old man in a high Western collar. "Is this a king? Whose king has a face like that?" She squints at the numbers and the strange curling letters. "What does it say? Is it a spell?"

"No. It's just—"

"Is it a *curse*?"

A man at the next stall leans over to look. Then another. A woman with a basket of figs. Two porters from the wharf, dripping river

water.

The crowd closes in, the way crowds do, all at once.

"That's not papyrus."

"Look at the colours on it."

"Look at *him*. Look at his hair."

"Where's your mother, boy?"

"*Khat-su,*" someone says. Sand-foreign. It sounds like spitting.

Somebody else says, "Spy."

The word goes through the crowd like a match through dry grass.

Spy. Spy for who? Spy for Hatti. They send children now. Look at him, he's not even brown. Call the Medjay.

"I'm not a spy," I say, and my high voice cracks, and nobody hears it.

Over the heads of the crowd, two long wooden staffs are coming toward us. The men holding them have the lean, hard look of police everywhere: dark-skinned, bare-chested, with leather bands on their wrists and no patience in their faces.

Medjay. City police.

The bread woman holds up my ten-thousand-yen note to them like evidence.

Of course, I think. *Just another variable I didn't account for.*

I snatch the bill out of her floury fingers.

And I run.

◆

Small, I think, as I duck between the fig woman's legs. *I'm small. Use it.*

I go low through the crowd, under baskets, between knees, past a startled donkey's belly. Behind me, a staff cracks against somebody's

shoulder and a man yells. The Medjay are shouting for people to move. People don't move fast enough. People never do.

Breathe. You're small, not stupid. Small hides. Stupid dies.

Ahead of me, a two-wheeled cart sits tipped on its side by the wharf steps, its axle snapped in half. A man is kneeling beside it, cursing at the broken wood.

I hear a Medjay right behind me. His sandals slap the dirt. He's closing, because his legs are twice as long as mine.

I veer toward the cart. Grab the loose end of the broken axle as I pass. Yank it.

It swings out sideways, a long bar of wood, at exactly the height of a grown man's shins.

There's a crack, and a howl, and the slap of a body hitting the ground.

Fencing, I think wildly. *It's just distance and timing. It's just—*

The second Medjay comes around the cart from the other side.

There's nowhere left to go except the edge of the wharf.

Below the edge is a stone wall, as tall as two men. Below the wall is a strip of black river mud, and then the Nile.

I don't think about it. If I think about it, I'll stop.

I jump.

For one long second there's nothing under me. Then the mud hits me like a door. It's cold and stinking and deep, and I go in to my knees. Pain shoots up both legs. I fall forward onto my hands. The smell of fish and rot is so thick I gag.

I look up.

There's a soldier standing in the mud in front of me.

Not Medjay. A real soldier. A tall young man with a leather cap and a cowhide shield painted with black and white patches, and a

spear in his hand, and an expression of mild, tired surprise, as if small blond boys fall out of the sky in front of him every afternoon.

My hand goes to my hip.

There's no sword there. There's barely a hip there. It's a reflex from a fencing strip in another body, and it's useless.

I try anyway. I drop my weight back, the way I've done ten thousand times on a fencing strip, and feint left and go right.

My feet are stuck in the mud.

The butt of the spear takes me in the stomach.

It isn't even a hard blow. I can tell that it isn't. He barely swings. But this body weighs nothing, and it folds around the wood like wet paper, and every bit of air I have leaves me at once.

I'm on my face in the mud.

I can't breathe. I can't see. My whole world is the taste of river and the noise my own lungs are making, trying to remember how lungs work.

A hand grabs the back of my shirt and lifts me out of the mud like a kitten.

"Got him," the soldier calls up the wall. He sounds bored.

◆

They tie my wrists with rope. Rough palm fibre that bites the skin.

Then they march me back up through the market.

The crowd parts for the soldier and the Medjay the way water parts for a boat. People stare at me. Children point. An old woman makes a sign against evil with two fingers.

I keep walking.

And because I can't do anything else, I watch.

I watch who bows, and to whom. The Medjay nod to the soldier, not the other way around. Everyone steps aside for a man in long,

spotless white linen with a shaved head and a leopard skin over one shoulder. A priest. The soldier lowers his eyes to him too.

At the granary gate, a scribe sits cross-legged with a palette on his knees, counting sacks as they go in. Every sack is stamped with the ram of Amun. Next to him stands a guard who isn't a soldier and isn't Medjay. He wears the same white as the priest.

The temple guards its own grain. With its own men.

Whoever owns the grain owns Egypt.

So who owns the grain, Father?

I count my steps. Two hundred and forty from the wharf to the edge of the market. I map the turns. I note the gate, the guards, the scribe's ink pot, the cracked blue jar. I note that nobody in this entire market looks at the soldier's face when he passes, and nobody looks at the priest at all.

They see a child, dragged through the street on a rope.

They don't see me counting.

At the end of the market, there's another wharf, and a long, low boat with a reed canopy, and rowers waiting.

The soldier lifts me in like a sack of grain.

We push off. The city slides away behind us. The brown water is wide and slow and full of light. Ahead of us, on the far bank, past the green fields, stands a long white palace with painted columns, at the edge of the desert, on the side of the river where the Egyptians bury their dead.

I'm wet and filthy and shaking, and I can't feel my hands.

But I'm still holding the bill.

Nobody thought to take it from me. My fist closed around it in the mud and hasn't opened since.

A face no one here can read. A number no one here can count.

The only proof, in this whole world, that I'm not insane.

I hold on to it all the way across the river.

THE PALACE. AFTERNOON.

The cell is a hole.

That's all it is. A square pit cut into the rock under some back corner of the palace, with a wooden grate over the top and a ladder that they pull up after them.

The soldier doesn't use the ladder for me. He lowers me by the rope on my wrists until my toes are a body's length off the floor, and then he lets go.

I land on my side on cold stone. Something in my shoulder makes a noise I don't like.

The grate slams shut above me. A bar slides across it.

Footsteps leave.

I lie there in the dark and breathe, and listen to my own heartbeat, and smell river mud drying on my skin.

Get up, I tell myself.

I don't.

I lie on the floor of a pit in ancient Egypt, ten years old, tied like an animal, and for one long moment, I let myself feel all of it.

The tree. The weight. The broom stopping.

Soren's message, still unanswered. It will be unanswered forever now.

Six books in brown paper at Mrs. Hayashi's shop that no one will ever come to collect.

I wish I was ten again.

"……"

I press my forehead against the stone until it hurts.

Then I get up.

◆

"That was a long fall, for someone so small."

I freeze.

There's someone else in the pit with me.

As my eyes adjust, I see him: a man sitting against the far wall with his knees drawn up. Middle-aged, heavy around the middle, with a good linen kilt gone grey with dirt. His wig is gone. Without it, his shaved head looks naked and soft. His wrists are tied like mine.

"I didn't see you," I say.

My voice comes out formal, the way it does when I'm frightened. Each word placed carefully, like stepping stones.

The man's eyebrows go up. "You speak like an old scribe."

"I was taught by old people."

He laughs. It's a tired, kind laugh. "What did you do, little scribe?"

"I tried to buy bread."

"And what did you pay with?"

"The wrong thing."

He laughs again, harder, and then stops, and wipes his eyes with his tied hands.

"And you?" I ask.

He's quiet for a while.

"I am the overseer of granaries for the western district," he says. "Was. This spring, a decree came down in the king's name. My district's grain is to go to the house of Amun, to rebuild the god's temples. All of it. Even the seed for next year." He looks at his hands. "My workers have children. So I went to court, and I knelt, and I asked the king if he had truly ordered such a thing."

"That's all?"

"That's all." He smiles at me in the dark. "It turns out that is a great deal."

He asked whether the king had really given the order, I think. *Not whether the order was fair. Whether the king gave it.*

Which means he thinks someone else did.

My father would have liked this man. My father always said the most dangerous question in any court is *who actually decided this?*

"What will they do to you?" I ask.

"They'll weigh my heart," the overseer says simply. "And they will find it heavy. And afterward, someone will go to my tomb with a chisel and cut my name off the walls, so the gods won't know where to find me."

He says it the way you'd talk about rain.

"That is the real death, you know," he adds. "Not the knife. Being forgotten."

Don't let them forget his name.

I sit down beside him in the dark. Neither of us speaks again until the grate opens.

◆

They take us up together.

Through a kitchen court that smells of smoke and goose fat. Through a long colonnade where servants flatten themselves against the wall to let us pass. Through a pair of cedar doors as tall as a house.

And into the throne room.

It runs away from me like a forest made of stone. Two rows of columns as thick as tree trunks march toward the far end, each one painted to look like a bundle of lotus stalks, blue and green and gold, with open flowers at the top. Above them, the ceiling glitters with gold leaf. High up in the walls, narrow windows let in long, slanted

bars of sunlight, and through those bars drifts smoke, sweet and heavy, curling up from bronze lamps on tall stands.

Myrrh. The smell is so thick I can taste it.

Men stand in the shadows between the columns. Dozens of them. White linen, gold collars, heavy black wigs. They don't talk. They barely move. They stand like statues in a tomb, and they all turn their heads to watch us walk in.

The floor is painted.

That's what I'll remember later. Not the gold. The floor. Someone has covered the whole floor in plaster and painted it like a marsh: blue water, green reeds, fish swimming, ducks bursting up from the papyrus with their wings spread. It's so beautiful that for one second I forget to be afraid.

Then a hand on the back of my neck shoves me down onto it.

"Kiss the ground before the Lord of the Two Lands."

My face hits a painted fish.

◆

I keep my forehead down. But I can see sideways, along the floor, between the columns. And I can listen.

Somewhere ahead of me, a staff strikes stone three times.

A herald's voice announces a list of titles so long I lose count. *Strong Bull. Beloved of Amun. Lord of the Two Lands. Lord of Appearances.* And a name at the end of it.

I hear the name and stop breathing.

Tutankhamun.

I don't look up. If I look up now, they'll hit me. But my whole body goes cold, then hot, then cold again.

My father in the museum. His hand on my shoulder. A gold mask behind glass, with eyes painted in black and white and a face so

young it looked like a doll's.

King at nine years old, Kael. Think about that.

Dead at nineteen.

They bring the overseer forward first.

He goes down on his knees beside me. I can see his tied hands on the painted water, and the way they're shaking now, even though his voice in the pit was steady.

A new voice speaks.

It's soft. That's the first thing about it. Soft and deep and smooth, polite as a host welcoming guests, and it doesn't need to be loud, because the whole room goes silent the moment it begins.

"The overseer of the western granaries came before this court and asked whether the word of the king was truly the king's word." A pause, long and unhurried. "He has questioned the Lord of the Two Lands, in his own hall, before the gods. There is no greater disorder than that."

Another pause.

"Order before mercy. Let his heart be weighed."

I turn my head a fraction, just enough to see.

The voice belongs to a man standing at the foot of the dais, at the right hand of the throne.

He is very tall and very thin, so thin his robe hangs from his shoulders like it's hanging from a doorframe. The robe is deep indigo, embroidered with tiny golden figures that I know are hieroglyphs for Amun. His head is shaved and gleams in the lamplight, with a single ornament of gold above his brow. His face is narrow and calm, and there are thin raised scars on his cheekbones, too regular to be from any accident. A wide collar of blue lapis and red carnelian lies across his chest. In one hand, he holds a tall staff topped with a falcon's head.

His fingers are wrapped in strips of linen, like old bandages. Over the linen, he wears rings. Many rings. Gold, heavy, carved.

The Vizier, someone whispers behind me. *Amenhotep.*

Amenhotep?

I search my memory, the shelves and shelves of it. My parents' books. My mother's handwriting on the chart above my bed.

I don't remember a vizier named Amenhotep. Not under this king.

Either my father's books were wrong, I think, *or I am.*

The Vizier's eyes move across the room. They're light brown, almost gold in the lamplight, and they don't stop on anyone for long.

They pass over me.

They don't stop.

◆

A priest comes forward with a set of scales.

He's young, with a shaved head and a leopard skin, and he carries a small bronze balance on a stand, the kind I've seen painted on the walls of a hundred tombs. He sets it down on the painted floor in front of the overseer.

On one pan, he lays a single white feather.

On the other, he lays a little amulet of red stone, carved in the shape of a heart.

My stomach turns over.

I know this scene. Everyone who has opened a book on Egypt knows this scene. The Weighing of the Heart. A dead man's heart, weighed against the feather of Ma'at, of truth. If the heart is heavier than the feather, a monster with a crocodile's head devours it, and the soul dies forever.

But that happens after death. In the underworld. In front of Osiris.

Not in a throne room, in the afternoon, in front of a living man.

This wasn't in any of the books, I think. *The books only had the paintings on the tomb walls. Nobody wrote down what the living did with them.*

The priest lifts the balance by its handle. The pans swing.

I watch his hand.

I've always watched hands. Fencing teaches you that. The blade lies, the eyes lie, but the hand tells you where the attack is going a split second before it goes.

The priest's thumb slides down the bronze arm and rests, very lightly, on the pan with the heart.

The heart sinks.

"It is heavy," the priest announces. "The heart is heavy with disorder."

A murmur through the columns. Nobody sounds surprised.

"Ammit take it," someone says, and others repeat it, low, like a prayer.

"No," the overseer says. "No, Majesty, please, I only asked—"

Two guards lift him by the arms.

He doesn't fight. That's the worst part. He's a soft, heavy, middle-aged man who counts grain for a living, and he knows exactly how this ends, so he doesn't fight. He just looks back over his shoulder toward the throne, the whole way, as they drag him between the columns and into the shadow.

I hear him say, very quietly, "My name is—"

A wet, heavy *thunk.*

Then silence.

A servant girl hurries out from between the columns with a bucket and a cloth. She kneels down where the shadow ends and begins to scrub at something on the painted floor.

The scrubbing is the only sound in the hall.

I realise I'm shaking. I put my tied hands flat on the floor to stop it.

He asked who really gave the order, I think. *And they killed him for it. In front of the king. So the king could watch.*

The Vizier hasn't moved. He stands at the foot of the dais with his staff, perfectly calm, as if he has just watched someone pour wine.

◆

"The foreign boy," the herald calls.

The hand on my neck hauls me upright, onto my knees.

The soldier from the wharf steps forward and bows to a man standing beside the throne. "Commander Nakhtmin. A foreign child, taken in the market at the river. He paid for bread with this."

He grabs my wrists. He pries my fist open, finger by finger.

I don't let go easily. It doesn't matter. He's an adult, and I'm not, and in the end the bill comes free, crumpled and stained with mud.

He holds it up.

The court leans forward as one.

"What is it?"

"A spell. Look at the face on it."

"It's no writing I have ever seen. A cipher. A Hittite cipher."

"Look at the boy. Look at his *hair.*"

"Sent by Hatti to spy on the king."

"Sent to curse him."

"A child," someone says, doubtfully.

"A child is the perfect spy. Who looks at a child?"

"Majesty." A fat official with a heavy gold collar steps forward and bows low. "The law is clear. A foreigner taken in the city, with sorcery in his hand. Let his heart be weighed."

"Let his heart be weighed," others echo.

The young priest picks up his scales again.

The feather on one side. The red stone heart on the other.

He doesn't even bother to reset them.

Don't panic. My heart is hammering so hard I can see my vision pulse. *Think. They see a child. What does a child get that a man doesn't? Pity? There's no pity in this room. Mercy? He just watched a man die for asking a question.*

"I am no spy," I say.

My voice rings out, high and bright, in that perfectly silent hall.

And every word is wrong. The words are too careful, too old, too formal for the face they're coming out of. I can hear it as I speak, the way the court hears it: a little boy talking like a priest who's a hundred years old.

"I am a traveller from very far away. I was robbed and left in the city with nothing. That paper is all I have. I meant no harm to the king, and I would never—"

The hand on my neck slaps me across the back of the head, hard enough that I see white.

"You do not speak in the presence of the king unless he bids you speak."

The court murmurs. Not angry. Uneasy. A few of them step back from me, and one makes the sign against evil.

Good job, Kael. You've just proved you're a demon.

I lift my head anyway.

For the first time since they dragged me in, I look up the steps of the dais. Past the Vizier and his indigo robes. Past a broad-shouldered young man standing beside the throne like a wall, with a curved bronze sword at his hip and a scar along his jaw and dark eyes that don't blink.

To the throne.

It's gold. All of it. Gold leaf over carved wood, with lion heads on the arms and lion feet on the legs, and wings of inlaid blue and red stone wrapped around the back. It's beautiful, and it's enormous. It was built for a grown man. For a god.

The boy sitting in it doesn't fill half of it.

He's nine years old.

He's small and fine-boned and very still, with brown skin and a narrow face, wearing a striped headdress of blue and gold that falls to his shoulders, with a golden cobra rearing at his forehead. A wide golden collar inlaid with lapis covers his thin chest like armour. Someone has tied a false beard to his chin, a long braided thing of blue and gold, and it looks heavy and wrong on a face that young.

His feet don't reach the footstool.

They dangle above it, in little gold sandals. And the footstool beneath them is painted with figures of foreign prisoners, men with their arms tied behind their backs, lying face down, so that the king can rest his feet on his enemies.

Bound foreigners.

Like me.

The boy isn't looking at the court. He isn't looking at the priest or the scales. His dark eyes have gone to the Vizier, and stayed there, waiting, the way a child in class watches the teacher to see what the answer is supposed to be.

His fingers are wrapped tight around a black stone scarab pinned to his collar.

He's not in control here, I think. *He's not in control of anything.*

He's the only person in this room who's as trapped as I am.

The priest lifts his scales.

And the king of Egypt turns his head, and looks down the steps, and finds me looking back.

Our eyes lock.

His are very dark, very tired, much older than nine. For a long moment, neither of us moves.

Then something in his face changes.

It's small. A loosening around the eyes. The look of someone who has been alone in a crowded room for a very long time, and has just noticed that someone else is too.

His fingers let go of the scarab.

The king lifts one small hand.

That's all. He doesn't stand. He doesn't speak. He just raises his hand from the arm of the golden throne, palm out, the way a child in a classroom asks permission to talk.

The priest freezes with the scales in the air.

The whole hall freezes with him.

I can feel it, the way you feel a change in air pressure before a storm. Dozens of grown men in gold collars, all of them suddenly unsure what they're supposed to do. They look at the raised hand. Then, one by one, I watch their eyes slide sideways to the foot of the dais.

To the Vizier.

Amenhotep doesn't move. He doesn't look up at the king. He stands with his staff and his rings and his calm, narrow face, and waits, as if he's curious what will happen next.

"Wait," the king says.

His voice is high and thin. It shouldn't carry in a hall that size. It carries anyway.

The fat official in the heavy collar bows so low his wig nearly brushes the floor. "Majesty. Lord of the Two Lands. The law is clear. A

foreigner, with sorcery in his hand—"

"The law says the king sentences."

Five words. Flat. No anger in them. Like a child reciting a lesson he's been made to learn by heart.

"Bring him."

◆

The hand on my neck hauls me to my feet and marches me forward, over the painted marsh, past the place where the servant girl is still scrubbing, until I'm at the bottom of the dais steps.

Close up, the boy is even smaller.

His wrists are thin as sticks under the gold bracelets. The false beard is tied on with a cord that's rubbed a red line under his jaw. His eyes are lined with black kohl, and under the kohl, there are shadows. He looks like he hasn't slept properly in a long time.

He looks at me.

I look back.

I shouldn't. Every instinct I have from three years of police stations and principals' offices tells me to lower my eyes, to make myself small and harmless and sorry. But I'm already small. And I'm tired of being sorry.

So I look back.

The king of Egypt studies me for a long moment. My blond hair, stiff with river mud. The strange blue shirt. The rope on my wrists. The scar through my eyebrow.

Then he says, quite clearly, so that the whole hall can hear:

"I shall sentence you."

The priest lowers the scales a little.

"By my royal authority," the king says, "I declare you to be my royal playmate and pet."

◆

For a second, nobody understands.

I don't understand. The words arrive in my head a half beat late, the way they all do here, and I have to hear them twice.

Playmate.

Pet.

Then the hall breaks.

It isn't loud. Courtiers don't shout. But the murmur rolls down the columns like a wave, and it's full of things that aren't quite words: shock, disgust, a few nervous laughs smothered behind hands.

The fat official straightens up, red-faced. "Majesty, with respect, the boy is a *foreigner.* He may be a spy, a sorcerer. He should be weighed, not—not *kept*—"

"He belongs to the king now."

"But the law—"

"The law says the king sentences."

"Majesty, surely the Vizier would counsel—"

"Pharaoh has sentenced."

The boy says it louder this time. Not much. But his voice cracks right down the middle of the word *Pharaoh*, and his small hand comes back to the black scarab on his collar and closes around it so tightly his knuckles go pale.

He's terrified.

He's nine years old, and he's terrified, and he's doing it anyway.

He found the gap, I think, and something in my chest goes very still. *The heart has to be weighed before the king. So he took the judgment for himself before they could finish. And the sentence he chose is one nobody can carry out with a knife.*

You can't execute the king's toy. It's his property.

That's not a child's trick. That's a lawyer's.

The silence after *Pharaoh has sentenced* goes on, and on.

Every face in the hall turns, very slowly, to the Vizier.

Amenhotep lets the silence stretch a little longer. Long enough that everyone feels it. Long enough that the king's hand tightens on his scarab one more time.

Then the Vizier bows.

It's a beautiful bow. Smooth and deep, his staff dipping, his rings flashing in the lamplight.

"As the Lord of the Two Lands wills," he says softly.

He straightens.

And for the first time, he looks at me.

It isn't a long look. A second. Less. His light, almost golden eyes rest on my face, and then on my eyes, and then they narrow, very slightly, the way a man narrows his eyes to read small writing.

He says nothing to me. Not a word.

He doesn't need to.

I've been looked at by a lot of adults. Teachers, police officers, social workers, the uncle in Osaka who wanted to take me in and didn't really want to take me in. I know the difference between a look that sees a child and a look that sees *me.*

This one sees me.

Marked, I think. *I've just been marked.*

Amenhotep turns to the scribe sitting cross-legged at the foot of the dais and holds out a ringed hand. The soldier from the wharf gives the scribe my muddy bill, and the scribe gives it to the Vizier.

He turns it over once in his linen-wrapped fingers. Looks at the stern old face. Looks at the numbers.

"Record it," he says, and hands it back to the scribe. "Keep it with the court's records. Curious things should be kept somewhere safe."

The scribe bows and tucks my bill into a cedar box.

I watch it go. The last piece of my world, shut in a box in a palace three and a half thousand years from home.

"Commander," the king says.

The young man beside the throne steps forward. Close up, he's built like a door, broad and square, with black hair pulled back so tightly it looks painful. The scar along his jaw is old and pale. His eyes look much older than the rest of him.

"Cut the rope."

"It will be done."

His voice is completely flat. He draws the curved bronze sword at his hip, and before I can flinch, the blade flicks down between my wrists. The rope falls away in two pieces.

The edge passed so close that I felt the cold of it on my skin. It didn't touch me.

That was a test, I think, rubbing my raw wrists. *Or a warning. Or both.*

Commander Nakhtmin sheathes his sword and steps back to his place beside the throne, and doesn't look at me again.

◆

The doors at the far end of the hall bang open.

A man stumbles in between the columns. He's covered in dust from his sandals to his hair, so grey with it he looks like a statue that's learned to run. Two guards are holding his arms, half helping, half dragging.

He drops to his knees on the painted floor and kisses it, and then he lifts his head and gasps out his message before the herald can even announce him.

"Majesty. From the garrison in the north. The men of Hatti have come down again. Another city that sent tribute to Kemet has opened

its gates to them. Its prince has sworn to their king. The roads north are closed."

The hall erupts.

Now they do shout. Men in gold collars push forward between the columns, talking over each other. *Hatti again. That's the third city. Send the army. We have no army to send, the treasury is empty. Then empty the temples. The temples are being rebuilt, by the king's own decree—*

Amenhotep raises his staff. Not high. Just a little.

The shouting stops.

"The council will hear it," he says gently. "In private. The king is tired."

Nobody asks the king whether he's tired.

But I'm not listening to the Vizier anymore.

I'm standing at the bottom of the dais steps, small and filthy and forgotten, and in my head my mother's chart is unrolling itself across the wall above my bed. The neat columns of names. The dates. The notes in the margins in her tiny, careful hand.

Amarna letters. Vassal kings in Canaan and Syria begging the pharaoh for help. Pharaoh doesn't answer. City after city goes over to the Hittites.

The Restoration Stela. Carved in this king's name. "The gods had turned their backs on this land. If an army was sent to Djahy to widen the borders of Egypt, it had no success."

No success.

I know this.

I know what's coming. Not all of it. Not the details. But I know which way the wind blows in this reign, because I grew up reading the end of the story. I know which wars go badly. I know which names last and which names get cut off the walls with chisels.

I know when this boy dies.

Every grown man in this hall is arguing about what will happen next, and none of them knows.

I do.

A child can't hold a sword, I think. *A child can't command a soldier, or sit on a council, or ask who really gave the order without ending up in the shadows behind the columns.*

But a child who knows what happens next…

That child would be worth keeping alive.

My hands are trembling again. Not from fear this time.

◆

"Come here."

The voice is very quiet, meant only for me.

The court is still muttering over the messenger. Nobody is watching the bottom of the dais. I climb two steps, then three, until I'm level with the painted footstool and the little gold sandals dangling above it.

The king leans down toward me. Up close, he smells of myrrh and of something else, plain and warm, like bread.

"What is your name?"

"Kael."

He tries it. "Kael." He says it carefully, like a word in a language he doesn't speak. It's the first time anyone in this world has said my name.

Then he says:

"You looked at him before you looked at me."

I go cold.

"Everyone looks at me first," the boy says. His voice is flat and soft and perfectly calm. "Then they look at him. To see if they were

allowed to." He tilts his head. "You didn't look to see if you were allowed. You looked to *watch* him."

"……"

The softness I saw in his face a few minutes ago is gone. In its place is something I wasn't expecting at all. His dark eyes move over me slowly, from my mud-caked hair to my bare feet and back again, and they're not the eyes of a lonely child.

They're the eyes of a player looking at a new piece on the board. Weighing what it's worth. Deciding where to put it.

He didn't just save me, I realise. *He acquired me.*

Because he saw what I saw. A boy in a room full of men who want to own him.

And he wants something of his own.

"Don't die quickly, Kael," the king of Egypt says. "Pharaoh is tired of new playmates."

Then he sits back on his enormous throne, and his face goes blank and polite and nine years old again, and he looks out over his arguing court as if I'm not there at all.

We are more alike, he and I, than anyone in this hall suspects.

I'm not sure yet whether that's going to save me or get me killed.

◆

The soldier from the wharf takes me away.

He doesn't drag me this time. He doesn't need to. He just walks, and I follow, because I'm the king's property now, and property follows.

As we pass between the columns, a courtier in a heavy wig leans to the man beside him and murmurs, not quietly enough, "The Pharaoh's Toy."

The other man laughs into his hand.

I keep walking. I count.

One hundred and twelve steps from the throne-room doors. Left at a painted pillar. Right past a courtyard with a dry fountain. Down three steps into a corridor that smells of lamp oil and old bread, where the walls are bare plaster and the doors are plain wood.

Servants' quarters. Close to the throne room. Close enough to be called when wanted.

The soldier stops at a heavy cedar door and pushes it open.

The room behind it is narrow, no wider than a man with his arms spread. A woven reed mat on the floor. A clay bowl of water. A single slit of a window, high up, letting in a bar of red evening light that lies across the floor like a blade.

He puts one hand between my shoulders and shoves, not hard. I stumble in and drop onto the mat.

He stands in the doorway for a moment, looking down at me. He's young, I realise. Maybe nineteen. He has a sunburned nose and tired eyes, and I don't think he's cruel. I think he's just someone who has stopped expecting things to end well.

"Sleep, little pet," he says. "Enjoy it while you can."

He starts to close the door. Then he stops, and adds, almost kindly:

"The last one lasted eleven days."

The door shuts.

A bar slides across it, on the outside.

◆

I sit on the reed mat in the dark.

The bar of red light on the floor goes purple, then grey, then nothing. Somewhere far off in the palace, a gong sounds, deep and slow, and the sound rolls through the walls and into my chest and fades.

I'm still wearing the blue shirt with red sleeves. It's stiff with dried mud. I can smell the river on my skin, and myrrh in my hair, and under it all, very faint, smoke. Old smoke. From my mother's books.

I pull my knees up to my chest. They're very small knees.

Somewhere in this palace, a man with linen on his fingers has my ten-thousand-yen note in a cedar box. Somewhere, a priest is putting his scales away for the night. Somewhere, a servant girl is wringing out a cloth. Somewhere, a nine-year-old king is lying awake in a bed too big for him, thinking about the new piece he's just put on his board.

And somewhere, very far away, a god with a face made of dust is watching a little hourglass.

Tick.

I think of the boy on the cherry road, laughing on the wet pavement in his blue shirt.

I think of my own voice, under the oldest tree, saying it to no one.

I wish I was ten again. Life was so much simpler.

I wished for a simpler life…

…and the gods gave me a palace full of people who want me dead.

◆ ◆ ◆

END OF CHAPTER 1

Next: Chapter 2 · The Shield of the Pharaoh